

**CULTIVATING SPIRITUAL MATURITY IN HEARING GOD:
AN AFFECTIVE-DOMAIN PEDAGOGY OF FORMATION
FOR INDIVIDUALS AND SMALL GROUPS**

Abstract. A companion to the argument that existing instruments measure spiritual maturity only at the lower levels of affective internalization, this article turns from diagnosis to cultivation. It argues that formation efforts fail for a reason parallel to the measurement problem: churches apply level-inappropriate interventions, pressing the disciplines of one level upon hearts and groups whose actual barrier lies at another. Using the same framework—Krauthwohl, Bloom, and Masia’s affective domain taxonomy together with the Parable of the Sower—it proposes that each transition between levels of internalization has a characteristic barrier and therefore a characteristic formational intervention, just as a gardener tends each soil differently.

It develops this transition-by-transition pedagogy at the individual and small-group scales, draws the reformed, evangelical, charismatic, and mystical traditions into a single formational toolkit so that each supplies the resource the others lack at the level where they characteristically plateau, and applies the whole to the cultivation of a heart—and a body—that hears and obeys God. Throughout it observes the boundary of its companion: formation tends conditions; the Spirit gives the growth.

Keywords. spiritual formation; means of grace; affective domain taxonomy; Krathwohl; Parable of the Sower; spiritual disciplines; small-group discipleship

Introduction: The Formation Problem

Churches want to know whether they are making disciples; they want even more to actually make them. A companion study to this one argued that the long failure to reach consensus on measuring spiritual maturity is not chiefly a failure of method but of taxonomic clarity: existing instruments conflate the levels of affective internalization described by Krathwohl, Bloom, and Masia, and so cluster at the lower levels—Receiving, Responding, and the near edge of Valuing—while the construct they claim to assess, character transformed by the indwelling Spirit, resides at the higher levels of Organization and Characterization.¹ That argument was diagnostic. It named where hearts and groups are, and why instruments cannot see them, but it deliberately stopped short of prescribing how a heart is moved from one level to the next. The present article is its formational complement; though it presupposes that argument, it restates what it borrows and can be read on its own.

The diagnostic argument has a constructive shadow. If instruments fail because they apply one level's method to another level's reality, formation efforts fail for the parallel reason: they apply one level's intervention to another level's barrier. We press the disciplines of Responding upon hearts whose actual obstacle is the hardness that precedes Receiving; we demand the integrated obedience of Organization from groups that have never been rooted; we try to manufacture by program and pressure the spontaneous fruit that belongs only to Characterization and only to time. The result is the familiar exhaustion of much discipleship: enormous effort expended at the wrong depth. As the measurement problem was a problem of fit

¹This article is the formational companion to “Measuring Spiritual Maturity in Hearing God: An Affective Domain Taxonomy for Individual and Small-Group Internalization” (hereafter “Measuring Spiritual Maturity”), and presupposes its diagnostic argument. On the underlying taxonomy, see David R. Krathwohl, Benjamin S. Bloom, and Bertram B. Masia, *Taxonomy of Educational Objectives: The Classification of Educational Goals; Handbook II: Affective Domain* (New York: David McKay, 1964).

between instrument and level, the formation problem is a problem of fit between intervention and transition.

The thesis of this article is that the same taxonomy that diagnoses also prescribes. Each transition between levels has a characteristic barrier—the companion study, reading the Parable of the Sower, named them: the hard path (no openness), the shallow root (no internal anchor), the choking thorns (no ordered hierarchy of loves).² A barrier named is an intervention specified. The gardener who knows why a plant is failing knows what to do and, equally important, knows what not to do, because the wrong intervention at a given transition does not merely waste effort; it can harden the very ground it means to soften.

Two clarifications govern everything that follows, and they mirror the two that governed the companion study. First, formation is cultivation, not manufacture. The taxonomy is, again, diagnostic of effects and prescriptive of conditions, not a technology of the Spirit's causation. We can plow, sow, water, weed, and wait; we cannot make the seed germinate. Jesus' own parable of formation, the seed growing secretly, sets the boundary exactly: "The kingdom of God is as if a man should scatter seed on the ground. He sleeps and rises night and day, and the seed sprouts and grows; he knows not how. The earth produces by itself" (Mark 4:26–28).³ The farmer's labor is real, necessary, and everywhere in the parable—scattering, sleeping, rising, finally putting in the sickle—but the decisive verb, "produces by itself," is not the farmer's. Paul says the same in the register of agriculture turned to ministry: "I planted, Apollos watered, but God gave the growth. So neither he who plants nor he who waters is anything, but only God who

²"Measuring Spiritual Maturity," on the four soils as points of failure in internalization. The parable appears at Matt 13:1–23; Mark 4:1–20; Luke 8:4–15.

³On the parable of the seed growing secretly (Mark 4:26–29) as Jesus' own depiction of growth that is at once genuinely cultivated and divinely given, see R. T. France, *The Gospel of Mark*, New International Greek Testament Commentary (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 2002), commentary on Mark 4:26–29. France notes the force of the adverb *automatē* ("by itself," v. 28): the earth's productivity is independent of the farmer's understanding or exertion.

gives the growth” (1 Cor 3:6–7). Everything this article proposes belongs to planting and watering. The growth is God’s.

Second, because the growth is God’s, the goal of formation is never to push a person or group up a ladder but to remove what obstructs and to supply what nourishes the work the Spirit is already doing. The levels are not rungs to be climbed by effort but conditions to be tended until, in due season, they yield. This reframes the whole enterprise. The pastoral question is not “How do I get this person to Level 4?” but “What is the barrier at this person’s actual transition, and what does faithful cultivation of that barrier look like, given that I cannot supply the growth?”

The article proceeds as follows. It first restates the taxonomy as a pedagogical map, converting each level boundary into a transition with a barrier and a remedy. It locates those remedies theologically in the historic means of grace. It then develops a transition-by-transition pedagogy for the individual heart, draws the four traditions into a single formational toolkit, extends the whole to the cultivation of a group’s collective soil, and applies the framework to the formation of a people who hear and obey God together. It closes by joining diagnosis and cultivation into a single pastoral cycle. Throughout, one domain of maturity serves as the running test of the pedagogy—the capacity to hear and obey God—both because the companion study took it as its own test case and because hearing God displays the whole arc with unusual clarity: it begins as the bare willingness to attend to a voice one scarcely recognizes and ends as a settled orientation in which that voice has become the air one breathes.

From Diagnosis to Cultivation: The Taxonomy as a Pedagogical Map

Krathwohl’s taxonomy orders the affective domain by the principle of internalization—the process by which an external value progressively becomes an internal, governing

characteristic of the person.⁴ Its five levels ascend from Receiving (willingness to attend), through Responding (active but externally motivated engagement), Valuing (intrinsic commitment), and Organization (the integration of the value into a coherent hierarchy), to Characterization (the value so settled that it has become the person's habitual identity, "pervasive, consistent, and predictable").⁵ The companion study mapped these onto the four soils of the Sower: the path is failure before Receiving; the rocky ground is Responding that never reaches Valuing; the thorny ground is Valuing that never reaches Organization; the good soil is Organization maturing into Characterization.⁶

Read diagnostically, the levels mark where a heart is. Read pedagogically, the boundaries between the levels mark where a heart must move, and each boundary has a characteristic barrier.

The fallow barrier (Level 0 to 1): hardness. Before anything can be received, the ground must be broken. The barrier is a surface that turns the seed away—inattention, self-sufficiency, the settled refusal to be addressed. Cultivation here is plowing.

The habit barrier (Level 1 to 2): inertia. The willing but unengaged heart must be moved into sustained practice. The barrier is the absence of formed habit; the seedling has no rhythm of watering. Cultivation here is scaffolding—the deliberate, external structuring of practice.

The root barrier (Level 2 to 3): extrinsic motivation. This is the decisive transition, from duty to desire, from compliance to conviction. The barrier is rootlessness or at least shallowness

⁴Krathwohl, Bloom, and Masia, *Affective Domain*, 35–38.

⁵Krathwohl, Bloom, and Masia, *Affective Domain*, 165–85. Characterization is described as behavior that is "pervasive, consistent, and predictable."

⁶"Measuring Spiritual Maturity," where the mapping of the four soils onto the levels of internalization is developed. On reading the parables as unified narratives whose points of correspondence are governed by the narrative whole, see Craig L. Blomberg, *Interpreting the Parables*, 2nd ed. (Downers Grove, IL: IVP Academic, 2012), 13–44.

of roots: behavior sustained only by external supports. Cultivation here is the slow watering of desire, which cannot be forced without producing the very rockiness it means to cure.

The order barrier (Level 3 to 4): disordered loves. The heart that genuinely values the kingdom must let that value reorganize all its other loves. The barrier is competing commitments held without hierarchy—good things that choke the best. Cultivation here is weeding: the costly subordination of rival loves.

The time barrier (Level 4 to 5): immaturity. The integrated heart must simply continue, under sun and rain, long enough for the value to become character. The barrier is not a defect to be removed but a duration to be endured. Cultivation here is patience, and the harvest is not ours to schedule.

The pedagogical map yields a single governing rule, the formational analog of the companion study's rule that instruments must be matched to levels: interventions must be matched to transitions. Plowing a heart that is already broken and weeping only wounds it; watering desire into a heart that has no habit of attendance runs the water off; demanding the reordering of loves from a heart that does not yet desire the kingdom produces either despair or hypocrisy. Much well-meant discipleship fails not because its practices are wrong but because they are right for a transition the person is not at. The gardener's skill is not in knowing one technique but in knowing which the soil now requires.

Two cautions temper this map before it is put to use. First, it is an idealization. Real hearts are not so orderly: the barriers co-occur and recur, a single person may be hard in one area of life and thorny in another, and movement is seldom the clean ascent of one transition at a time that a five-stage scheme suggests. The map names the dominant barrier—the one most pastorally salient at a given moment—and is meant as a way of locating the leading edge of the Spirit's

work, not as a claim that internalization proceeds by discrete steps; Krathwohl himself described the levels as a continuum, and the soils of the parable are kinds of reception before they are stages of a single life.⁷

The Means of Grace: Where Cultivation Gets Its Power

To call formation “cultivation” could imply that it is a human technique awaiting the right method. The historic Christian tradition resists that implication by locating the church’s formative power not in its programs but in the means of grace—the ordinary, appointed channels through which God himself communicates the benefits of redemption. The Westminster Shorter Catechism names them with precision: “The outward and ordinary means whereby Christ communicateth to us the benefits of redemption are his ordinances, especially the Word, sacraments, and prayer.”⁸ Calvin grounds the principle theologically: God deigns to use external means, accommodating himself to our weakness, so that the Spirit’s secret operation is ordinarily joined to Word, sacrament, and prayer rather than bypassing them.⁹ John Wesley, from another tradition, defends the same conviction against those who would await grace without means: the means are “outward signs, words, or actions ... ordained of God ... to be the ordinary channels whereby he might convey to men preventing, justifying, or sanctifying grace.”¹⁰

⁷ The parables’ primary referent is the reception of the kingdom proclamation, not a developmental theory of sanctification; the four soils are, in the first instance, four kinds of hearers rather than four stages of one life. The developmental and formational extension employed here is an illuminating analogy and pastoral heuristic, not an exegetical claim, and is held under the same caution against allegorizing the parables’ incidental details that governs sound interpretation; see Blomberg, *Interpreting the Parables*, 13–44. The New Testament’s own warning literature nonetheless applies these failure modes to established believers (cf. Heb 3–4; Rev 2–3), licensing the reading of the soils as recurring conditions of the heart in ongoing discipleship.

⁸ *Westminster Shorter Catechism*, Q. 88.

⁹ John Calvin, *Institutes of the Christian Religion*, ed. John T. McNeill, trans. Ford Lewis Battles, Library of Christian Classics 20–21 (Philadelphia: Westminster, 1960), IV.1.1; IV.14.3. Calvin argues that God accommodates himself to human weakness by joining his Spirit’s secret working to outward means.

¹⁰ John Wesley, “The Means of Grace” (Sermon 16), II.1, in *The Works of John Wesley*, vol. 1, *Sermons I*, ed. Albert C. Outler (Nashville: Abingdon, 1984), 376–97. Wesley defines the means of grace as “outward signs, words, or

The doctrine of the means of grace is precisely what keeps a level-matched pedagogy from collapsing into technique. The means are not levers we pull to produce internalization; they are channels we keep open so that the Spirit, who alone gives the growth, may work through the instruments he has chosen. This is the old distinction between primary and secondary causes, and it dissolves an apparent paradox: if growth is wholly God's gift, why should it matter which means is brought, or how fittingly? It matters because God ordinarily binds his working to his appointed means, so that they are genuinely efficacious as instruments without being the cause of what they convey—as the farmer's watering is truly necessary to a harvest no one can compel.¹¹ To match the means to the transition is therefore not to seize a lever the Spirit has left lying about, but to take up the instrument the Spirit is pleased to use, in the place he is pleased to use it; the taxonomy adds no new power to the means and no new mechanism to grace, but is only a map for the gardener's hand. What the affective taxonomy adds is a specification of which means does what work at which transition. The same Word that breaks the fallow ground—the law's plowing—becomes, later, the honey the maturing heart tastes and loves (Ps 119:103); the same prayer that begins as dutiful petition becomes the listening dialogue of the integrated life; the same fellowship that first merely assembles becomes the body through which the Spirit distributes a hearing no single member could receive alone. Cultivation is the pastoral art of bringing the right means to bear at the transition where the Spirit is pleased to use it.

Existing Formation Frameworks Through the Affective-Domain Lens

actions ... ordained of God ... to be the ordinary channels whereby he might convey to men preventing, justifying, or sanctifying grace."

¹¹ On the genuine efficacy of second causes under God's primary causality—and so on the means as real instruments rather than the cause of what they convey—see *Westminster Confession of Faith*, V.2–3 ("God, in his ordinary providence, maketh use of means"); and Calvin, *Institutes*, I.16.2–9.

The companion study surveyed six widely used measurement instruments and, analyzing them through the affective domain taxonomy, found that they cluster at Levels 1–3, with none reliably reaching Levels 4–5.¹² A parallel survey of the major families of formation practice yields a structurally identical result. Where the instruments cluster at the lower *levels*, the frameworks cluster their interventions at the lower *transitions*: most are concentrated on the habit-building work of the passage from Receiving to Responding, only one addresses the decisive duty-to-desire transition head-on, and the ordering and ripening transitions are reached only by high-cost, low-throughput practices or by models that presuppose what they cannot themselves produce. The aim of the survey is not to fault any framework—each does real and necessary work—but to show that none is full-spectrum, and that their characteristic concentration explains why so much earnest formation stalls at precisely the hinge the companion study identified. The six families examined here are chosen as the most widely adopted in English-language evangelical and broadly catholic practice; the list is illustrative rather than exhaustive, and several formative streams are deliberately left aside.¹³ Six families warrant examination.

The Spiritual Disciplines Tradition

The recovery of the classical disciplines—led by Richard Foster’s *Celebration of Discipline* and given theological architecture by Dallas Willard’s *The Spirit of the Disciplines*—is the most influential formation framework of the past half-century.¹⁴ Analyzed through the

¹² “Measuring Spiritual Maturity,” surveying six instruments through the affective domain taxonomy and finding that they cluster at Levels 1–3.

¹³ Among the streams left aside: the Wesleyan class meeting and band; the ancient catechumenate; the Eastern Orthodox ascetical tradition of theosis; virtue- and character-formation in the recovery of the virtues; therapeutic and inner-healing models; and the contemporary neuroscience of habit. Each would repay analysis through the same lens, and none, on the present argument, would be expected to alter the clustering the survey identifies.

¹⁴ Richard J. Foster, *Celebration of Discipline: The Path to Spiritual Growth*, rev. ed. (San Francisco: HarperSanFrancisco, 1998); Dallas Willard, *The Spirit of the Disciplines: Understanding How God Changes Lives*

taxonomy, its native work lies at the rhythm-building transition and, at its best, the watering of desire: it supplies the practices—prayer, fasting, study, solitude, service—that move a willing heart into sustained engagement. Both Foster and Willard insist, rigorously, that the disciplines are means of receiving grace and never achievements, and that to mistake the practice for the maturity is to court legalism. Yet in popular adoption the disciplines are frequently deployed as a Level-2 scaffold mistaken for the building: a person who faithfully “does the disciplines” is presumed mature, which is exactly the Responding-assumed-to-be-Characterization error the companion study named the Pharisee problem. The tradition names the whole arc; in practice it most reliably cultivates its lower reaches.

Discipleship-Pathway and Class-Ladder Models

A second family operationalizes formation as movement along a designed pathway—sequential classes, “next steps,” membership-to-maturity ladders, and the discipleship curricula that underwrite them, of which *Transformational Discipleship* is a representative statement.¹⁵ These models are the formative counterpart to the very assessment instruments the companion study faulted; they often share a vendor and a vocabulary. Their characteristic level is Responding: they motivate and track by completion—classes finished, steps taken, content covered—and they presuppose that curricular progress tracks internalization. Their value at the lower transitions is real, where external structure is exactly the right help. Their danger is the indistinguishability problem in formative dress: a pathway cannot tell whether the participant

(San Francisco: Harper & Row, 1988). Willard’s governing principle is that transformation cannot be achieved by direct effort but is received as we arrange our lives around the practices that place us where God can act.

¹⁵ Eric Geiger, Michael Kelley, and Philip Nation, *Transformational Discipleship: How People Really Grow* (Nashville: B&H, 2012). The same volume informs several of the assessment instruments examined in the companion study.

who has “completed the track” now values the kingdom or has merely performed the steps. The ladder cultivates Responding well and assumes the rest.

Liturgical and Catechetical Formation

A third family targets, deliberately and almost alone, the duty-to-desire transition. James K. A. Smith’s liturgical anthropology argues that human beings are shaped less by the ideas they are taught than by the practices they repeatedly perform, so that the way to re-form shallow or disordered loves is to immerse them in counter-formative worship and habit.¹⁶ The older catechetical tradition, recovered in works such as Packer and Parrett’s *Grounded in the Gospel*, makes the same wager on slow, repeated, embodied instruction that forms affection and not merely knowledge.¹⁷ This family is to the formation survey what the Spiritual Assessment Inventory was to the instrument survey: the one approach that squarely names the hardest problem—how extrinsic practice becomes intrinsic love—and builds toward it rather than around it. Its limit is the obverse of its strength: liturgical formation works diffusely, corporately, and on a long horizon, shaping the loves of a whole congregation over years; it resists individual targeting and gives the pastor little purchase on why this particular heart remains at the rocky-ground transition.

Spiritual Direction and the Examen

A fourth family—classical spiritual direction together with the Ignatian examen—reaches higher than the others, into the ordering transition. Direction’s sustained, individuated attention is built precisely to surface and re-rank the disordered loves that choke the thorny-ground heart,

¹⁶ James K. A. Smith, *Desiring the Kingdom: Worship, Worldview, and Cultural Formation* (Grand Rapids: Baker Academic, 2009); and *Imagining the Kingdom: How Worship Works* (Grand Rapids: Baker Academic, 2013).

¹⁷ J. I. Packer and Gary A. Parrett, *Grounded in the Gospel: Building Believers the Old-Fashioned Way* (Grand Rapids: Baker, 2010). On the parallel with the Spiritual Assessment Inventory as the lone instrument that squarely addresses the self-report validity problem, see “Measuring Spiritual Maturity.”

and the daily examen trains a person to notice where their affections actually went, exposing the gap between professed and operative loves.¹⁸ Of all the frameworks surveyed, direction most directly cultivates the work of Level 3 to Level 4. Its constraint is throughput: like Fowler's clinical interview in the instrument survey, one-to-one direction is labor-intensive, depends on scarce skilled directors, and cannot scale to a congregation. It cultivates the right transition for the few it can reach.

Rule-of-Life and Monastic Rhythms

A fifth family orders the whole of life around a structured rhythm: the monastic Rule, of which Benedict's remains the archetype, and its contemporary adaptations in the "rule of life" and new-monastic movements and in works such as Ruth Haley Barton's *Sacred Rhythms*.¹⁹ By design the Rule aims at Organization: it subordinates every hour, relationship, and possession to a single ordering love, which is the very Level 3-to-4 work of integrating competing commitments under one priority. Its theological ambition is therefore the highest of the structural frameworks. Yet in popular adoption the Rule often functions, for most participants, as an unusually elaborate Level-2 scaffold—a richer set of practices undertaken from the same external motivation—so that the structure intended to express ordered love becomes instead one more thing performed, a more beautiful thorny ground. The Rule prescribes Organization; whether it cultivates it depends on a transition it cannot itself guarantee.

Discipleship-Multiplication Models

¹⁸ David G. Benner, *Sacred Companions: The Gift of Spiritual Friendship and Direction* (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 2002). On the examen as a discipline for surfacing the gap between professed and operative loves, see the discussion of the classical contemplative heritage in "Measuring Spiritual Maturity."

¹⁹ *The Rule of St. Benedict in English*, ed. Timothy Fry (Collegeville, MN: Liturgical Press, 1981); Ruth Haley Barton, *Sacred Rhythms: Arranging Our Lives for Spiritual Transformation* (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 2006).

A sixth family makes reproduction the goal: the disciple-making lineage from Robert Coleman's *The Master Plan of Evangelism* to Greg Ogden's *Transforming Discipleship* and the triads and micro-groups it has shaped.²⁰ These models aim highest of all, at the passage from Characterization to reproduction, by treating the capacity to form others as the mark and proof of maturity—the very test the companion study's small-group taxonomy placed at Level 5. Their insight is that mature formation is inherently generative, and that a disciple who cannot reproduce has not fully internalized. Their limit is that they presuppose the lower transitions they do not themselves cultivate: a multiplication model can structure and accelerate reproduction once desire, ordered loves, and settled character are present, but it cannot manufacture them, and a reproduction culture imposed on Responding-level disciples reproduces only the performance. The model cultivates the top transition for those already near it.

Summary: The Clustering Problem

Surveyed through the taxonomy, the frameworks reveal a pattern that mirrors the instrument survey with uncanny precision. Just as the instruments clustered at Levels 1–3 and thinned toward Levels 4–5, the frameworks cluster their reliable cultivation at the lower transitions and thin toward the higher ones. The passage from Receiving to Responding is richly served—by the disciplines, the pathways, and the outer structure of the Rule. The decisive duty-to-desire transition is addressed head-on by only one family, the liturgical, and then only diffusely and slowly. The ordering transition is reached well by direction, but at a throughput no congregation can sustain. And the ripening into Characterization is, as the companion study argued, beyond the direct reach of any framework; the multiplication models that aim there

²⁰ Robert E. Coleman, *The Master Plan of Evangelism*, 2nd ed. (Grand Rapids: Revell, 1993); Greg Ogden, *Transforming Discipleship: Making Disciples a Few at a Time* (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 2003).

presuppose it. Two further observations sharpen the parallel. First, most programmatic, scalable frameworks are *level-blind*: they prescribe the same practice to every participant regardless of the transition they actually face—the individuated practices, spiritual direction and mentoring, are the exception, and their resistance to one-size prescription is exactly why they cannot scale—which is the formative form of the indistinguishability problem—the identical discipline pressed alike on the heart that needs plowing and the heart that needs watering.²¹ Second, the frameworks thin out in exactly the region where the companion study located the measurement wall, and this is no coincidence: the transitions that resist measurement—the interior shift from extrinsic to intrinsic motivation, and everything above it—are the same transitions that resist programmatic cultivation, because measurement and manufacture run aground on the same reality, the hiddenness and freedom of a heart that only the Spirit can change. This is not a counsel of despair but the warrant for the pedagogy that follows: rather than ask which framework to apply wholesale, it asks of each heart and each group which cultivation its actual transition now requires.

Cultivating the Individual Heart: A Transition Pedagogy

Breaking Up the Fallow Ground (Level 0 to Level 1 Receiving)

The hard path cannot receive the seed, and no amount of better sowing will change that; the soil itself must be opened. Scripture’s own image for this work is agricultural and unsentimental: “Break up your fallow ground, and sow not among thorns” (Jer 4:3); “Sow for yourselves righteousness; reap steadfast love; break up your fallow ground, for it is the time to seek the LORD, that he may come and rain righteousness upon you” (Hos 10:12). Fallow ground

²¹ “Measuring Spiritual Maturity,” on the indistinguishability problem and the “measurement wall” at the transition from extrinsic to intrinsic motivation.

is not barren ground; it is ground capable of fruit but compacted by long disuse. The plow that breaks it is, in classic Protestant understanding, the law—not as condemnation merely but as the instrument that exposes the hardness and ends the illusion of self-sufficiency.²² Conviction, honest lament, the disorienting witness of a transformed life, and suffering that cracks the settled surface are all plows. The pastoral temptation here is to sow more seed—more teaching, more invitation—on ground that has not been broken; the seed is snatched away (Matt 13:19) not for lack of sowing but for lack of plowing. Yet here above all the gardener’s limit is stark: the gardener may drive the plow, but cannot soften the heart. That is a divine prerogative, “I will remove the heart of stone from your flesh and give you a heart of flesh” (Ezek 36:26) and so the plowing of this transition is inseparable from intercession. In the matter of hearing God the barrier is simply deafness—the fallow heart is not yet disobedient so much as unable to attend—and the plow’s first work is to expose that God has been speaking all along to ground that would not listen. We plow in hope and pray for rain.

Establishing the Rhythm (Level 1 Receiving to Level 2 Responding)

The newly opened heart is willing but not yet engaged; it must be moved into sustained practice, and at this transition external structure is not a compromise but the appointed help. A rule of life, an accountable relationship, a fixed time and place, an assigned reading—these scaffolds supply from outside the regularity the heart cannot yet supply from within.²³ The reformed and evangelical traditions have rightly insisted that the spiritual disciplines are means, not ends: Foster and Willard both warn that the disciplines are a means of receiving God’s grace,

²²On the law’s first or “pedagogical” use, which exposes sin and ends the illusion of self-sufficiency, see Calvin, *Institutes*, II.7.6–9; on the preconditions of renewal more broadly, Richard F. Lovelace, *Dynamics of Spiritual Life: An Evangelical Theology of Renewal* (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 1979).

²³On a rule of life and the deliberate structuring of practice in early formation, see M. Robert Mulholland Jr., *Invitation to a Journey: A Road Map for Spiritual Formation* (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 1993).

never a self-improvement technology, and that to mistake the practice for the maturity is to manufacture precisely the Pharisaism the companion study diagnosed.²⁴ Two opposite errors threaten here. The first despises the day of small things (Zech 4:10), refusing the scaffold because it feels mechanical—but the seedling’s watering is mechanical by design; regularity precedes delight. The second mistakes the scaffold for the building, settling permanently into externally motivated practice and calling it maturity. The scaffold is right for this transition and wrong as a destination; its purpose is to hold the structure until the next transition can make it internal. For hearing God this is where listening is first practiced: the fixed hours of Scripture and prayer are the listening posts at which one learns, however mechanically at first, to attend to a voice not one’s own.

From Duty to Desire (Level 2 Responding to Level 3 Valuing)

Here is the hinge of the whole formational arc, and the transition most resistant to direct effort. The shift from Responding to Valuing is the shift from extrinsic to intrinsic motivation—from reading Scripture because the plan requires it to reading it because one wants to, from serving by obligation to serving from conviction.²⁵ It cannot be willed directly, because the will to desire is not yet desire; one cannot, by deciding, make oneself delight. This is the structural reason the rocky-ground hearer fails: the response was real but externally sustained, and no increase of external pressure can convert pressure into love. The cultivation proper to this transition is therefore indirect—the slow watering of the affections by exposure to the goodness

²⁴Richard J. Foster, *Celebration of Discipline: The Path to Spiritual Growth*, rev. ed. (San Francisco: HarperSanFrancisco, 1998); Dallas Willard, *The Spirit of the Disciplines: Understanding How God Changes Lives* (San Francisco: Harper & Row, 1988). Both insist that the disciplines are a means of receiving grace, never a technology of self-improvement, and that mistaking the practice for the maturity reproduces the very Pharisaism the companion study diagnoses.

²⁵“Measuring Spiritual Maturity,” on the extrinsic-to-intrinsic shift as the defining mark of Valuing; cf. Krathwohl, Bloom, and Masia, *Affective Domain*, 139–53.

of the thing itself. “Oh, taste and see that the LORD is good!” (Ps 34:8) is an invitation, not a command to manufacture appetite; appetite is awakened by tasting. Jonathan Edwards named the faculty in question the “sense of the heart,” a perception that finds divine truth not merely correct but beautiful, and he insisted that such perception is given, not generated.²⁶ The contemporary work of James K. A. Smith translates the same insight into the language of habit and liturgy: our loves are formed less by what we are told than by what we repeatedly practice and behold, so that the road to desire runs through embodied, beauty-laden practice rather than through more information or more pressure.²⁷ Smith corrects a purely cognitive model without displacing the Word: desire is first awakened by a true sight of God in the gospel—the very apprehension Edwards described—and the Word remains its native food, so that embodied practice deepens and steadies a desire that right vision has kindled rather than manufacturing one out of habit alone; affection and apprehension are allies at this transition, not rivals. And indirection is not passivity. There is real cultivation to be done, only of an oblique kind, and its practices are the ones that set the heart before the goodness of God without demanding a response: reading Scripture slowly, for delight rather than for completion; the meditation that lingers over a single text until it yields its sweetness; worship, music, and beauty received to be tasted rather than analyzed; and the company of others whose desire proves contagious. What these share is that they offer where pressure demands. The decisive pastoral discipline here is restraint. To press, shame, or demand at this transition is to compact the soil—to make the practice more external

²⁶Jonathan Edwards, *Religious Affections*, ed. John E. Smith, Works of Jonathan Edwards, vol. 2 (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1959), 96–100. Edwards distinguishes a merely “notional understanding” from the “sense of the heart,” a new spiritual perception of divine beauty that is given by the Spirit, not generated by the will.

²⁷James K. A. Smith, *Desiring the Kingdom: Worship, Worldview, and Cultural Formation* (Grand Rapids: Baker Academic, 2009); and *You Are What You Love: The Spiritual Power of Habit* (Grand Rapids: Brazos, 2016). Smith argues that human beings are fundamentally desiring creatures whose loves are calibrated by embodied, repeated practice rather than primarily by information.

precisely when it must become more internal. The gardener waters and waits; the Spirit gives the taste. In the hearing of God it is the same passage—from listening because one ought to listening because one longs to, from bringing God dutiful questions to wanting, more than anything else, to know what he is saying.

Ordering the Loves (Level 3 Valuing to Level 4 Organizing)

The thorny ground bears a genuine plant; its failure is not the absence of value but the absence of hierarchy. The heart that truly values the kingdom must now let that value reorganize every other love, “for where your treasure is, there your heart will be also” (Matt 6:21), and “no one can serve two masters” (Matt 6:24). Augustine gave this work its classic name: *ordo amoris*, rightly ordered love, in which virtue is nothing other than loving the right things in the right degree.²⁸ The thorns of “the cares of the world and the deceitfulness of riches” (Matt 13:22) are not, for the most part, evil loves; they are good loves held without subordination—family, security, reputation, comfort—that choke the best because they have never been ranked beneath it. Cultivation at this transition is weeding, and weeding is costly because the weeds are dear. Its instruments are those that surface and re-rank competing loves: the examen, which traces the day’s actual affections to expose where treasure truly lies; spiritual direction and honest community, which see the disordered love the owner cannot; scenario and decision, which force the abstract value into concrete conflict—not “Do you value generosity?” but “When generosity threatens your family’s security, what do you do?”; and above all the practiced relinquishments—fasting, simplicity, sacrificial giving—that deliberately deny a rival love in

²⁸ Augustine, *The City of God against the Pagans*, trans. R. W. Dyson (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1998), XV.22, defining virtue as rightly ordered love (*ordo amoris*); cf. *On Christian Teaching*, trans. R. P. H. Green (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1997), I.27–28.

order to discover whether the kingdom is in fact loved more.²⁹ “Seek first the kingdom of God and his righteousness” (Matt 6:33) is the rule of this transition; the practices are the ways the heart learns to mean the word “first.” Here hearing becomes the organizing voice: the word now loved above its rivals becomes the word by which the rivals are ranked, so that to hear God is increasingly, and of one piece, to obey him.

Waiting for the Harvest (Level 4 Organizing to Level 5 Characterization)

The final transition cannot be cultivated by any new technique, because its barrier is not a defect but a duration. Characterization is the value so long settled that it has become the person—fruit borne “with patience” (Luke 8:15), the spontaneous produce of a tree that has simply grown. One cannot aim directly at it; the person who tries to manufacture settled character produces only the self-conscious performance of it, which is its opposite. What the integrated heart needs at this transition is not more formation but faithful continuance under sun and rain—Eugene Peterson’s “long obedience in the same direction.”³⁰ Two of the means appointed for this duration are unwelcome. The first is suffering, which Scripture names as the ordinary furnace of mature character: “suffering produces endurance, and endurance produces character” (Rom 5:3–4). The second is the withdrawal of felt consolation that the mystical tradition calls the dark night, in which God removes the sensible sweetness of his presence precisely so that obedience may grow roots deeper than feeling.³¹ Neither can be programmed;

²⁹On scenario-based discernment and value-conflict assessment, see “Measuring Spiritual Maturity” (criteria for Level 4). On fasting and simplicity as the practiced subordination of rival goods, see Foster, *Celebration of Discipline*, chaps. 3 and 5.

³⁰Eugene H. Peterson, *A Long Obedience in the Same Direction: Discipleship in an Instant Society*, 2nd ed. (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 2000).

³¹John of the Cross, *Dark Night of the Soul*, trans. E. Allison Peers (New York: Image Books, 1959), I.8–11; II.1–3. The dark night of the senses strips dependence on felt consolation so that the will may cleave to God beneath the level of feeling.

both can be received. The gardener's task in this season is the humblest of all—to keep the ground, refuse despair through apparent fruitlessness, and trust the parable: “he sleeps and rises night and day, and the seed sprouts and grows; he knows not how” (Mark 4:27). “And let us not grow weary of doing good, for in due season we will reap, if we do not give up” (Gal 6:9). The harvest is the Spirit's, on the Spirit's calendar; the farmer's part is to still be in the field when it comes. And hearing God, at the last, is no longer an act the person performs but the orientation the person lives from—settled, unselfconscious, and, like all the fruit of this final transition, recognized by others before it is noticed by the one in whom it has grown.

The Four Traditions as a Formational Toolkit

The companion study observed that each of four great traditions—reformed, evangelical, charismatic, and mystical—tends, in popular practice, to plateau at a characteristic level: the reformed at Responding (excellent doctrine without affective internalization, Lovelace's “sanctification gap”); the evangelical at the Responding-to-Valuing edge (active practice, compartmentalized life); the charismatic at Valuing (genuine encounter, dependence on felt experience); the mystical at the Valuing-to-Organization edge (deep interiority without costly obedience).³² Diagnostically, the lesson was that no single tradition produces full-spectrum maturity. These are tendencies of lived congregational culture, not ceilings imposed by any tradition's theology: each stream carries its own corrective—Reformed theology its Edwards, the charismatic its sober discerners who test the spirits, the contemplative its desert ascetics and a John of the Cross whose dark night issued in the most costly obedience, the evangelical its missionaries and martyrs—so that the plateaus mark where each stream at its popular worst tends

³²“Measuring Spiritual Maturity,” on the characteristic plateau of each tradition in popular practice; on the reformed “sanctification gap,” Lovelace, *Dynamics of Spiritual Life*, 26.

to halt, not where its best theology would let it rest. Pedagogically, the lesson is more constructive and more surprising: the intervention one tradition lacks at its plateau is exactly the intervention another tradition has perfected. The plateaus are complementary, and formation advances by deliberate cross-pollination.

Consider the transitions in turn. The fallow-ground plowing of Level 0–1 is the reformed tradition’s native strength—the law’s exposure of the heart, the high doctrine of sin and sovereign grace that breaks self-sufficiency—and it is exactly what the more affirming streams often lack. The watering of desire at Level 2–3, where the reformed tradition characteristically plateaus, is the native genius of the charismatic and mystical streams: the charismatic insistence that God is encounterable now, the mystical cultivation of the heart’s taste for beauty. That the reformed tradition plateaus here is a fact of popular practice, not of its theology: Edwards’s own account of the “sense of the heart” is a watering resource the tradition supplies to itself, and Lovelace’s “sanctification gap” names exactly the distance between reformed theology and reformed practice. The weeding of disordered loves at Level 3–4, where the mystical tradition tends to stall in interiority, is supplied by the reformed doctrine of lordship and worldview—“whether you eat or drink ... do all to the glory of God” (1 Cor 10:31)—and by the evangelical insistence on concrete, missional obedience that drives the interior life outward into costly action. And the patient endurance of Level 4–5 draws on the mystical tradition’s hard-won wisdom of the dark night, which the activist traditions, allergic to fruitlessness, most need to learn.

The practical upshot is a formational strategy rather than a tribal loyalty. A congregation formed wholly within one tradition will, predictably, carry its people to that tradition’s plateau and stall—not because the tradition is false but because no tradition is complete. The skilled

formator therefore borrows: reformed plowing for the affirming heart that has never been broken; charismatic and mystical watering for the doctrinally sound heart that has never tasted; evangelical obedience for the contemplative who has never paid; mystical night-wisdom for the activist who has never waited. The traditions are not competitors for the same ground but specialists for different seasons of the one cultivation. “They all need each other,” the companion study concluded;³³ read as pedagogy, that sentence is a toolkit.

Cultivating the Group’s Soil: A Parallel Formation Pedagogy

The companion study extended the taxonomy to the small group, showing that a group develops a collective “soil condition”—a shared receptivity that is a property of the relational system, not merely of its members—and that this group soil can be hard, rocky, thorny, or good independent of the individual receptivity of those in the room.³⁴ If the group’s soil is its culture, then forming a group is cultivating that culture, and the same transition pedagogy applies, with one decisive addition drawn from group-dynamics research: the norms that will govern a group’s whole life are set, and hardened, in its earliest meetings.³⁵

This makes the founding of a group the single most consequential formational act in its history. A group that begins with surface-level sharing establishes a norm of surface-level interaction that, Levi’s research shows, becomes nearly impossible to break.³⁶ The path-group’s hardness is usually not a later corruption but an original norm: the meeting format itself—content consumed passively, discussion kept abstract, relationships left untouched—functions as packed

³³“Measuring Spiritual Maturity,” concluding the analysis of the four traditions.

³⁴“Measuring Spiritual Maturity,” on the group’s collective “soil condition” as a property of the relational system rather than of its individual members.

³⁵Daniel Levi and David A. Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 6th ed. (Thousand Oaks, CA: SAGE, 2021), 67–78, on the persistence of norms established in a group’s earliest meetings.

³⁶Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 67–78.

earth from the first night. The pedagogical implication is that good soil is planted, not repaired: the decisive cultivation happens before the norms set, when the leader can establish from the outset that this is a place of genuine question, honest disclosure, and shared discernment. Re-plowing a group whose hard norms have already cured is possible but far costlier than founding it well.

The leader's role across the group's transitions is best understood as a deliberately receding presence—the gardener who does progressively less as the soil matures. At Assembling (Level 1) the leader is the teacher, and necessarily central. At Interacting (Level 2) the leader becomes the asker of genuine questions—not curriculum questions whose answers are already in hand, but real ones that hand the work to the members—and the group's first true disagreement becomes the pivotal formational event: a leader who suppresses it to preserve comfort cures into the group an avoidance norm that can freeze it permanently, while a leader who shepherds the group through honest conflict plants the root system the rocky-ground group lacks.³⁷ At Trusting (Level 3) the leader's instrument is self-disclosure: because trust is caught from the front, the leader who first confesses real struggle converts the group's performative trust (“we say we are vulnerable”) into normative trust (“our actual behavior supports disclosure”), the very distinction on which group maturity turns.³⁸ At Integrating (Level 4) the leader's task is to distribute leadership and then to step back—even to engineer a planned absence—undertaken with discernment, and with the group prepared, so that it is received as entrustment rather than desertion—since Levi's leadership-absence test (does the group function when the leader is

³⁷Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 131–48, on conflict types and the consequences of suppressing early conflict; cf. Bruce W. Tuckman and Mary Ann C. Jensen, “Stages of Small Group Development Revisited,” *Group and Organizational Studies* 2, no. 4 (1977): 419–27, on the “storming” phase.

³⁸Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 72–74, applying Amy C. Edmondson, “Psychological Safety and Learning Behavior in Work Teams,” *Administrative Science Quarterly* 44, no. 2 (1999): 350–83. On the distinction between performative and normative trust, see “Measuring Spiritual Maturity.”

gone?) is not only a diagnostic but a formational practice: the absence is the trellis removed so the plant can bear its own weight.³⁹ And at Reproducing (Level 5) the leader's final act is sending—releasing members to plant new groups, which the mature group experiences not as loss but as harvest.⁴⁰

The group transitions thus mirror the individual ones. Founding good norms is the group's fallow-ground plowing. Moving from leader-centered assembling to mutual interaction is its rhythm-building. The conversion of performative into normative trust is its duty-to-desire transition—and, exactly as with individuals, it cannot be forced: a leader who demands vulnerability produces performance, the group's version of compacted soil. The subordination of the group's comfort, harmony, and self-preservation to the word's costly demands is its weeding of disordered loves—the most common reason groups “persist for years, meeting faithfully, sharing warmly, and producing nothing of kingdom consequence.”⁴¹ And the long, patient sustaining of corporate discernment through seasons of drought—what the companion study called the group's “corporate dark night”—is its waiting for the harvest.⁴² Bonhoeffer's warning presides over the whole: a community built on a human ideal of fellowship rather than on the divine reality already given will be shattered when the ideal fails, whereas a community received as God's gift can bear the disillusionment that genuine formation requires.⁴³

³⁹Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 197–215 (distributed leadership) and 153–55 (team reflexivity).

⁴⁰Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 255–58 (organizational learning transfer); on disciple-making reproduction, see Greg Ogden, *Transforming Discipleship: Making Disciples a Few at a Time* (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 2003).

⁴¹“Measuring Spiritual Maturity,” describing the thorny-ground group.

⁴²“Measuring Spiritual Maturity,” describing the good-soil group and the “corporate dark night.”

⁴³Dietrich Bonhoeffer, *Life Together*, trans. John W. Doberstein (New York: Harper & Row, 1954), 26–30. Bonhoeffer warns that community built on a human ideal rather than on the divine reality already given inevitably collapses into disillusionment.

Hearing and Obeying God Together: Cultivation Applied

The companion study applied the taxonomy to one domain of maturity—hearing and obeying God—at both the individual and group scales. That capacity has been the running thread of the present article as well; what follows gathers it into an explicit set of practices for cultivating hearing, level by level, under the same governing rule: match the practice to the transition.

For the individual, the progression runs from reception to default orientation. At the lower transitions the cultivation is establishing exposure and rhythm: sitting under the Word preached and read until the conviction that God speaks becomes a settled habit of attention. At the duty-to-desire transition it is the practice of listening prayer—bringing a real question to God and attending, unhurried, to what stirs—precisely because listening cannot be performed for an audience and so tends to form genuine rather than displayed desire.⁴⁴ At the ordering transition it is the integration of hearing into actual decisions, the mature framework that weighs Scripture, prayer, counsel, and circumstance together: “Trust in the LORD with all your heart, and do not lean on your own understanding” (Prov 3:5–6).⁴⁵ At the final transition it is simply the accumulated life in which hearing has become reflexive—“my sheep hear my voice” (John 10:27)—and which is, again, recognized rather than manufactured.

For the group, the fundamental shift is that the Spirit distributes hearing across the body: “To each is given the manifestation of the Spirit for the common good” (1 Cor 12:7); “when you come together, each one has a hymn, a lesson, a revelation” (1 Cor 14:26). One member receives, another tests, another sees the application, another finds the courage to act; no single

⁴⁴Dallas Willard, *Hearing God: Developing a Conversational Relationship with God* (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 2012), 67–95.

⁴⁵Willard, *Hearing God*, on a mature framework that weighs Scripture, prayer, counsel, and circumstance together.

person carries the whole signal. Cultivating corporate hearing therefore means building the practices through which the distributed signal can be assembled. At the trusting transition this is corporate listening prayer: the group prays a specific question, then shares what each received, noting convergences and weighing divergences, learning to discern together rather than to defer to the most confident voice.⁴⁶ At the integrating transition it is the regular submission of individual leadings to the group for testing, and the group's willingness to hear God about itself—its own health, blind spots, and calling. And the paradigm of the whole is Acts 13:1–3, where the gathered leaders of Antioch worshiped, fasted, heard the Spirit together, and obeyed at great cost by releasing their two best leaders, producing the Gentile mission that changed history.⁴⁷ That is the harvest of cultivated corporate hearing: a body so formed in shared discernment that it can hear God say something costly and obey together.

Implications and Conclusion

This article has argued that the failure of much spiritual formation is, like the failure of spiritual measurement, a failure of fit: not too little effort but effort applied at the wrong transition. Krathwohl's taxonomy, read pedagogically rather than diagnostically, converts each boundary between levels into a transition with a characteristic barrier and a corresponding cultivation—fallow-ground plowing, rhythm-building, the watering of desire, the weeding of disordered loves, and patient waiting for the harvest—at both the individual and the small-group scales.

⁴⁶On corporate listening prayer and shared discernment, see Willard, *Hearing God*, 67–95; cf. Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 149–52, on shared mental models.

⁴⁷On Acts 13:1–3 as the paradigm of corporate discernment issuing in costly obedience, see “Measuring Spiritual Maturity.”

Several implications follow, each a constructive mirror of the companion study's. First and governing: match the means of grace to the transition, as measurement must match the instrument to the level. The Word, prayer, sacrament, and fellowship do different work at different transitions; the pastoral art is to bring the right one to bear where the Spirit is pleased to use it, and to withhold the intervention a given transition cannot bear—above all to refrain from pressing duty's methods onto the duty-to-desire transition, where force compacts the very soil it means to open.

Second, cultivate; do not manufacture. Formation removes barriers and supplies nourishment; it does not produce growth. The whole enterprise is bounded by the parable of the seed growing secretly: the farmer's labor is everywhere and indispensable, and yet "the earth produces by itself," and "he knows not how" (Mark 4:27–28).

Third, treat the traditions as a toolkit, not a tribe. Because each tradition plateaus where another is strong, full-spectrum formation requires deliberate cross-pollination: reformed plowing, charismatic and mystical watering, evangelical and reformed weeding, mystical night-wisdom for the long wait. A church formed within one stream alone will carry its people faithfully to that stream's plateau and stop.

Fourth, diagnosis and cultivation form one pastoral cycle. The companion study supplies the diagnostic half: read the soil—of a heart, of a group—and locate the actual transition and its barrier. This article supplies the cultivating half: apply the level-appropriate means, then wait on the Spirit and watch for fruit, which, being the Spirit's produce, is recognized rather than self-certified. The cycle then repeats: re-read the soil, re-match the means. Measurement without cultivation is mere diagnosis; cultivation without measurement is undirected effort. Together they are pastoral care.

Fifth, the scope of this proposal must be stated as plainly as its companion stated its own. Like the measurement framework, this is a theoretical and pastoral argument, not an empirical finding; its illustrations are composite rather than documented cases, and its central claim—that cultivation matched to the diagnosed transition bears more fruit than cultivation applied indiscriminately—has not yet been tested. It constitutes, in the companion’s terms, a first stage: it specifies what level-appropriate cultivation would involve and why mismatched intervention stalls. A second stage would pilot these cultivations with real directees and groups, asking whether transition-matched formation actually outperforms one-size practice and whether the barriers named here are the ones that, when cultivated, give way. The framework is offered as a hypothesis disciplined by Scripture and pastoral experience, falsifiable in principle and awaiting the field—and where the preceding pages speak of practices that “cultivate” or “produce,” the claim is throughout dispositional: the means place a heart where the Spirit may act, never that they compel the growth.

Two composite illustrations, paired with the companion study’s, show the cycle at work. The first is individual. The companion study described a directee who, asked what she noticed when she missed her Scripture reading during a family crisis, admitted she had felt relief rather than loss—a response diagnosing a Level 2–3 transition no instrument would have caught.⁴⁸ The formational question is what to do next, and the level-matched answer is counter-intuitive: not more discipline, which would compact the soil, but the patient watering of desire. The director adds no reading plan but, for a season, lifts the obligation—a discerning, situational judgment rather than a rule, depending on whether the trouble is genuine over-obligation or mere neglect—and instead invites the directee to read only what she finds beautiful, slowly, without

⁴⁸“Measuring Spiritual Maturity,” first composite illustration.

requirement—to taste and see—trusting that desire, unlike duty, cannot be commanded into being but can be awakened by exposure to goodness. The second illustration is corporate. The companion study described two groups identical on the assessment but observably at Levels 2 and 4: the first cancelled when its leader was absent, let two members carry the conversation, and redirected its first disagreement to a safe curriculum question.⁴⁹ The formational prescription matches the transition: because the group’s hard norms have already begun to set, the work is re-plowing. The leader stops teaching and starts asking real questions, goes first in honest disclosure to convert performed trust into the real thing, withdraws for a fortnight to force distributed ownership, and shepherds, rather than redirects, the next real conflict, because the root system the group lacks can grow only through the honest disagreement it has been avoiding. Neither prescription is a technique guaranteed to work, because neither supplies the growth. Both are simply the cultivation proper to the diagnosed transition.

The honest conclusion of this analysis matches the honest conclusion of its companion. The companion study ended in the humility of measurement: the heart’s hiddenness means we can measure what we can measure, name what we cannot, and trust the One who searches hearts. Formation ends in a parallel humility, but it is the humility of labor rather than of limitation. We plow the fallow ground and pray for rain we cannot send; we scatter the seed and cannot make it sprout; we water desire we cannot command; we weed loves that are dear and wait for fruit on a calendar not our own. “So neither he who plants nor he who waters is anything, but only God who gives the growth” (1 Cor 3:7). This is not the humility of those who can do nothing—the farmer’s labor fills the parable—but the humility of those who, having plowed and sown and watered and weeded and waited, still cannot make a single seed germinate, and so do their

⁴⁹“Measuring Spiritual Maturity,” second composite illustration.

indispensable work with open hands. The kingdom comes as the seed grows: the farmer sleeps and rises, night and day, and the earth produces by itself, and he knows not how. Our part is to tend the soil and stay in the field. The growth is God's.

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